

UNIVERSITY OF ESSEX

Second and Third Year Examinations 2009

SC301-6-FY CURRENT DISPUTES IN SOCIOLOGY: SOCIOLOGICAL ANALYSIS III

Time allowed: 3 hours

Candidates must answer **THREE** questions: **ONE** from **SECTION A**, **ONE** from **SECTION B** and **ONE** from **EITHER** Section.

The paper consists of 18 questions

Paper dictionaries (with the title in English) **are** allowed to be taken into this examination.

Please do not leave your seat unless you are given permission by an invigilator

Do not communicate in any way with any other candidate in the examination room.

Do not open the question paper until told to do so.

All answers must be written in the answer book(s) provided.

All rough work must be written in the answer book(s) provided. A line should be drawn through any rough work to indicate to the examiner that it is not part of the work to be marked.

At the end of the examination, remain seated until your answer book(s) have been collected and you have been told you may leave.

SECTION A

1. Present and critically assess the main premises of the empiricist tradition in sociology.
2. Discuss the main similarities and differences between the epistemological approaches of Georg Simmel and Max Weber.
3. What implications does critical realism have for the methodology of social science?
4. Discuss the main points of disagreement between Popper and Kuhn regarding the development of natural sciences.
5. Is scientific knowledge a product of social factors or the reflection of the 'natural' phenomena that scientists observe?
6. Critically analyze different feminist epistemologies' accounts of the relationship between gender and knowledge.
7. What is meant by the phrase 'The West and the Rest'?
8. What, if anything, has post-structuralism contributed to social theory?

END OF SECTION A

SECTION B

9. Is contemporary society a disciplinary society?
10. How useful is the notion of cultural capital for understanding contemporary society?
11. How can signs be ideological?
12. Outline and assess how sociologists have characterised the key features of modernity?
13. How useful a term is 'postmodernity' for contemporary social theory?
14. Critically discuss contemporary feminist discussions of 'sex' and gender.
15. Should sociology talk of 'feminisms' rather than 'feminism'?
16. Is it useful to explain contemporary social problems in terms of the tensions between systems and the lifeworld, as Habermas does?
17. 'The monological ideal seriously underestimates the place of the dialogical in human life' (Charles Taylor). Discuss this statement using examples from debates generated in contemporary social movements to illustrate your answer.
18. What does James O'Connor mean by 'the second contradiction of capitalism'? Evaluate his attempt to combine Marxian sociology with ecology.

END OF SECTION B

(END OF PAPER)